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Getting Started with AlphaCONNECT™

Door to door data delivery

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Getting Started with AlphaCONNECT
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PART 1 - INTRODUCTION

Imagine having information from practically anywhere in the world—any World Wide Web or Internet FTP site, or any computer on your local network—copied to the PC on your desk automatically, so every morning you have the data you need: stock prices, inventory levels from all your branch offices, the latest weather report, or just about anything else. And not only is it on your PC, it's already in the format you want it: a Word or WordPerfect document, Excel or Quattro Pro spreadsheet, Access or Paradox database, or even on a World Wide Web page. You can have all of this, and more, with AlphaCONNECT.

What AlphaCONNECT Does

AlphaCONNECT is so powerful because it combines two technologies which until now have been separate: data communication, which copies information from another computer to yours, and data conversion, which takes that information and puts it in the format you need for your application. The combination of these abilities means AlphaCONNECT can read a text file or World Wide Web page from any computer you can reach on your local network or the Internet, copy the information—or just the parts of it you want—to your PC, then put it in the right format in your target application.

AlphaCONNECT is actually a collection of seven different components. Six of them work with particular Windows applications: Microsoft Word, Excel, and Access, WordPerfect, Quattro Pro, and Borland Paradox. Each of these can also create a very simple World Wide Web page (HTML file). The seventh component is specifically for creating Web pages, and offers many more options and capabilities than the Web page creation feature of the other components.

To make AlphaCONNECT even more powerful, we created the Scheduler. With the Scheduler, you can tell AlphaCONNECT to run links at any time you choose. You can even have links repeat regularly, so you can have hourly stock quotes, or the latest weather report every morning. And, with the AlphaCONNECT Messenger add-on email capability, you can send the information you get from AlphaCONNECT on to anyone you can reach via email—automatically.

How AlphaCONNECT Works

AlphaCONNECT works through "links." A link is a definition which tells AlphaCONNECT what information to retrieve and where to place it on your PC. For example, a link may tell AlphaCONNECT to take the second through fifth columns of an inventory report from your branch office and put the information in columns B, D, F, and G of your Excel spreadsheet called INVENTRY.XLS.

AlphaCONNECT offers over a hundred sample links you can use as soon as you install it, giving you access to everything from the latest weather forecast to current census figures. We've even included sample links complete with data, so you can see how AlphaCONNECT works right away.

For those of you interested in seeing "underneath" your software, here's what happens when you run a link:

1. Based on the link definition, AlphaCONNECT searches your PC, your LAN, or the Internet for the data source file.
2. Using the correct protocol for the type of data source (either FTP or HTTP), it connects to the remote computer, copies the file to a temporary file on your PC, then disconnects.
3. AlphaCONNECT starts the target application (such as Word or Excel) if it isn't running and creates a new file or opens the existing file defined in the link.
4. Using the data conversion method you've chosen, AlphaCONNECT opens the temporary file, reads the parts of it defined in the link, and inserts it into the target application file.
5. Based on option settings, AlphaCONNECT either leaves the target application file open or saves it and shuts down the application. It can also use FTP to copy the file to a remote computer for you, and, if you have AlphaCONNECT Messenger, email the result to anyone you choose.

Defining your own links is easy. Just tell AlphaCONNECT where the information you want is, what parts of it to retrieve, and where to put it on your PC. For step-by-step examples, see part 3 of this book.

AlphaCONNECT Product Structure

The AlphaCONNECT product consists of seven components, one for each target application it works with. Each component has its own desktop icon and button on the AlphaCONNECT Task Bar (see below for more on the Task Bar). So, when you start AlphaCONNECT, you start only the component for the application—Word, Excel, the World Wide Web, etc.—that you want to create or run a link for. This component structure saves you disk space by letting you install only the software you'll actually use; if you don't have one of the target applications—and very few people will have them all—you don't need to store the AlphaCONNECT component which supports it.

The eighth AlphaCONNECT component is the Task Bar, which is always installed. The Task Bar provides you with a fast way to start any other AlphaCONNECT component, including AlphaFTP, AlphaCONNECT's included FTP client program. It also contains the Scheduler, which lets you schedule any AlphaCONNECT link to run automatically at any time you choose.

About This Book

As the title *Getting Started* implies, this book is an introduction to AlphaCONNECT. It contains the following sections:

- Part 1, “Introduction,” describes what AlphaCONNECT can do for you, and how it does it.
- Part 2, “Installation and Startup,” talks about the AlphaCONNECT installation program, starting AlphaCONNECT, and setting AlphaCONNECT’s options to match your PC’s configuration. It also covers compatibility issues when you’re using an on-line service for Internet access, and how to set up your target applications to ensure the best possible results.
- Part 3, “Tutorial,” takes three of the sample links included with AlphaCONNECT and shows you, in detail, exactly how we created them. We selected these links to show a cross-section of AlphaCONNECT’s abilities. One of them uses a local data source included with AlphaCONNECT so you can look at and run it immediately.
- Part 4, “Overview,” briefly describes each of AlphaCONNECT’s features, and the options and choices you have when you create a link.

Except in the tutorial section, this manual does not go into great detail about how to use AlphaCONNECT. There are a couple of reasons for this: first, we think AlphaCONNECT is easy enough to use that, after looking at the tutorials, you’ll be able to make it do what you want it to; and second, more detailed information is available on-line while you’re using AlphaCONNECT. There are two types of on-line information:

- AlphaCONNECT’s key features offer cue cards, which let you see exactly what to put in the current field, right on your screen.
- A standard Windows hypertext help file includes step by step instructions, explanations of each feature, and more.

Conventions This Book Uses

To make our explanations easier to understand, we use some special typefaces and other conventions to let you know what we’re talking about. These are:

Convention	Meaning
Main Menu	When we refer to the title of one of AlphaCONNECT’s screens, or the name of a field on a screen, each word starts with a capital letter.
Cancel	When we talk about one of the “buttons” on a screen, the button name is in italics.

`Text`	When we refer to a message you may see on your screen, we print it in this typeface.
`Text`	When we tell you to type a specific character or characters on your keyboard, we print them in this bold type. For example: type **`Y`**.
ENTER	When we tell you to press a key on your keyboard, we use this small capital typeface. If you need to press two or more keys at once, we connect the key names with a plus sign. For example: CTRL+Y. If you need to press two or more keys in succession, we put a comma between the key names, like this: ALT, T

Boxed Information

In addition, whenever there's information which isn't part of the most common way to use a feature, but which you might need from time to time, we put it in a box like this.

To Contact Us

If you have a question about AlphaCONNECT, or a problem, and you can't find the answer in the on-line help or in this manual, here's what you can do:

- Look at the list of frequently asked questions (FAQs) on our World Wide Web page: *http://www.alphamicro.com/ac* We update the FAQs frequently based on the information we get from our users.
- If you haven't yet purchased and registered your copy of AlphaCONNECT, call 888/226-6398 or send email to us at this address: *aconnect@alphamicro.com.*
- If you have registered AlphaCONNECT, call us at 800/487-7877. Telephone support is free for the first 30 days after you register; after that, there will be a per-call charge, so please have your credit card available when you call.
- If you just have a question, and an immediate response isn't critical, you can send email to *support@alphamicro.com* or send us a fax at 714/641-7605. We'll respond to email and fax issues as time is available, so you may have to wait a few days for an answer.

PART 2 - INSTALLATION AND STARTUP

This chapter describes:

- Hardware and software requirements
- Internet compatibility considerations
- AlphaCONNECT's installation program
- Setting AlphaCONNECT's options to match your PC configuration
- Setting options in AlphaCONNECT's target applications to ensure optimum performance

Prerequisites

You can install and use AlphaCONNECT on any PC which runs one of the supported operating systems (listed below). It requires about 1MB of memory in addition to the memory used by its target application. For best results, we suggest a 486 or better CPU and at least 8MB of memory (for optimum performance, we recommend 16MB). You also need a connection to your local area network (LAN) and/or the Internet so you can contact the computers you want to retrieve data from.

AlphaCONNECT works under Windows for Workgroups 3.11, Windows '95, or Windows NT. To use it to retrieve data from FTP or World Wide Web sites, you need a Winsock 1.1 compliant TCP/IP stack. TCP/IP is included with Windows '95; for Windows for Workgroups and Windows NT, it is available free from Microsoft.

INTERNET CONNECTION NOTES

When using AlphaCONNECT with a dial-up Internet service, you must make your connection before starting a link. AlphaCONNECT cannot open your Internet connection for you.

Many on-line services' default configurations allow only the on-line service program to have Internet access. Other programs, such as AlphaCONNECT or Netscape, may not work in the default configuration. This is a limitation of the on-line service, not of AlphaCONNECT. In many cases, you can enable external programs, including AlphaCONNECT, by changing the on-line service setup.

For instructions on how to configure on-line services to work with AlphaCONNECT, see the AlphaCONNECT on-line help (look up the service name in the search index) or the FAQ list on our World Wide Web site.

Also, when working over the Internet, please keep in mind the uncertainties of long-distance—even international—phone and network connections. Almost any Internet link

will fail occasionally, due to the unavailability of the host. Just run the link again a little later, and you'll have the information you want.

Installation

There are two ways to acquire the AlphaCONNECT software: download it from AlphaCONNECT's World Wide Web site at *http://www.alphamicro.com/ac,* or request a set of diskettes from Alpha Microsystems.

You can download AlphaCONNECT from the World Wide Web either as a single file of about 5MB, or as four smaller files. If you download it as a single file:

1. Make sure you know what directory you downloaded the AC.EXE file into. You can start the installation in either of these ways:

   - In the File Manager, find AC.EXE and double-click it.
   - From the Program Manager or the File Manager, select the File Menu, choose Run, and type the full path for AC.EXE in the Command Line field. For example, **`c:\temp\ac.exe`**. Select *OK* or press ENTER.

   Either method extracts AlphaCONNECT's installation files from the compressed CONNECT.EXE file and starts the installation program.

If you download AlphaCONNECT from the Web as four files, they are called AC1.EXE, AC2.EXE, AC3.EXE, and AC4.EXE. Make sure you know what directory you downloaded them into. Then:

1. You need to decompress each file before running the installation program. The easiest way to do so is to use the File Manager to view the directory where they are, and double-click each file.

   The program which decompresses the files lets you choose what directory to put the new files into. We suggest you use the default, C:\TEMP. You can use a different directory if you want to, but you must decompress all four files into the same directory.

2. After decompressing all files, run SETUP.EXE in one of these ways:

   - In the File Manager, view the directory where you put the decompressed files. Find SETUP.EXE and double-click it.
   - From the Program Manager or the File Manager, select the File Menu, choose Run, and type the full path for SETUP.EXE in the Command Line field. For example, **`c:\temp\setup.exe`**. Select *OK* or press ENTER.

To install AlphaCONNECT from the installation diskettes:

1. From either the File Manager or the Program Manager, select the File Menu and choose Run.
2. In the Command Line field, type: **`a:\setup`**. Select *OK* or press ENTER.

THE INSTALLATION PROGRAM

The installation program displays a series of screens, asking you whether this is a new installation or an update, which directory you want to install AlphaCONNECT in, which components you want to install, and so on. You also have the option of installing AlphaCONNECT in "run-only" mode, so this PC can only run existing links, not modify them or create new ones.

After you've made your selections and answered all of the installation program's questions, it begins decompressing AlphaCONNECT's files from the installation files. If you're installing from diskette, change diskettes when it asks you to do so.

Choosing Samples

AlphaCONNECT includes hundreds of sample links, covering areas from literature to census data to the weather forecast. You can choose the samples you want by selecting Sample Links when the installation program asks you which components to install. This displays a list of the types of samples for you to choose from.

After decompressing the files, the installation program creates program icons for AlphaCONNECT in the program group you selected. It then asks if you want to set the paths to your application software. AlphaCONNECT needs to know where the software for its target applications is—the Word component needs to know where Microsoft Word is, and so on. It's easiest to set this during the installation process. If you choose not to, you can do so later using the Options feature, as described below.

After it finishes, the installation program asks if you want to restart Windows or your computer. Depending on their system configuration, some users need to restart Windows or reboot their PC to make sure all the system files which come with AlphaCONNECT are properly updated. If you choose not to restart immediately, you may not be able to use AlphaCONNECT until you do.

Windows NT Users—AlphaCONNECT is not compatible with the "Run in Separate Memory Space" option. Do not check this option on the Properties dialog box for any of the AlphaCONNECT programs. Also, make sure it is not set for any of AlphaCONNECT's target applications.

INSTALLING THE TASK BAR

The AlphaCONNECT Task Bar has several benefits: it lets you start any AlphaCONNECT component by clicking a button, it gives you direct access to AlphaCONNECT's help file and AlphaFTP, and, most importantly, it lets you schedule links to run automatically at any time. The Task Bar program also starts each scheduled link at the proper time.

An icon for the Task Bar is placed in the program group with the other AlphaCONNECT components during installation. We strongly suggest you copy this icon to your Startup program group, so the Task Bar starts automatically when you start Windows. For your links to start as scheduled, the Task Bar program ***must*** be running at the scheduled start time; if you schedule a link, then close the Task Bar, the link will not run as scheduled.

Starting AlphaCONNECT

You have a couple of choices for starting an AlphaCONNECT component:

- Start it like any other program from the Windows 3.1 Program Manager or Windows 95 desktop.
- If the AlphaCONNECT Task Bar is visible, click the button for the component you want.

A Shortcut

You can set up AlphaCONNECT so you can start it by using a menu option, toolbar button, or keyboard shortcut from inside the target application. For example, you could add an AlphaCONNECT command to Microsoft Word's Tools menu.

For instructions on using this feature, see AlphaCONNECT's on-line help.

When you install AlphaCONNECT, you can use it for up to thirty days without purchasing and registering the software. Each time you start a component, a screen tells you how many days you have left, and asks if you want to register. If you don't want to register AlphaCONNECT yet, select *Test Run* to go to the Main Menu.

When you are ready to register, you need to contact Alpha Micro to get your registration code. See the on-line help topic "Registering AlphaCONNECT" (just select *Help* from the registration screen) for details.

Setting Options

The installation program sets AlphaCONNECT's options for you based on the answers you give it. You can start running the sample links or defining your own links right away. But, you may want to change some of the option settings to make AlphaCONNECT act more like you want it to. For example, you can tell it where to appear on your desktop, what World Wide Web browser you use, and more. To change the option settings:

1. From the Main Menu of any AlphaCONNECT component, select View, then select Options (or press CTRL+O).
2. There are four tabbed screens of option settings:
    - Defaults: connection information for the default host computer, and what you want AlphaCONNECT to do after running a link.

- Application: information and options about the target application and the data import method you want to use. The name of this tab changes for each component—it is always the same as the target application.
- Network: describes the FTP and World Wide Web software you want to use with AlphaCONNECT.
- Miscellaneous: controls certain aspects of AlphaCONNECT's appearance and behavior.

The settings on the Network and Miscellaneous tabs are global—you only need to change them once for all AlphaCONNECT components. The Defaults and Application tabs are unique to each component to allow maximum flexibility. For a description of each option field, use the Cue Card feature on the Options screen.

Target Application Settings

AlphaCONNECT interacts with its target applications as it imports data. Because of this, the options you have selected for your applications may affect the way an AlphaCONNECT link runs, and, in some cases, may even keep a link from completing. Look up the target applications you use in this list to see how their option settings may affect AlphaCONNECT:

- All: For best results, maximize the file window within the application window (for example, the Word document within the Word window). This adds the application file name to the window title bar, allowing AlphaCONNECT to find the file if it is open.
- Microsoft Word: Make sure the "Tip of the Day" feature is off. If you view a tip each time Word starts, AlphaCONNECT will not be able to start Word and open the target document.

  If you have the "prompt for summary info" option turned on, AlphaCONNECT will not be able to save the destination document and shut down Word when a link finishes.
- Excel: If you have the "prompt for summary info" option turned on, AlphaCONNECT will not be able to save the destination worksheet and shut down Excel when a link finishes.

  If you use the DDE import method, you may want to turn off auto-calculation. The repeated calculations as data is imported can significantly slow down the link.
- Access: In Access 2.0, make sure the Ignore DDE Requests option on the View Options menu is set to no.
- Netscape: If you use Netscape Mail, and Netscape requests a mail password when it starts, AlphaCONNECT will be unable to start Netscape successfully.

This information is also available in the on-line help topic “Application Option Settings.”

PART 3 - TUTORIAL

Sometimes, the best way to learn something is by looking at an example and seeing how it was created. That's what this section does. We'll take three of the sample links included with AlphaCONNECT and show you how we defined them, explaining each step of the process. The three links we discuss are:

- A Microsoft Word link which retrieves news headlines from CNN's World Wide Web site.
- A Microsoft Excel link which retrieves national employment statistics from an FTP server.
- A Web link which creates a Web page from a text file, included with Alpha-CONNECT, containing state census figures. This information was originally downloaded (using AlphaCONNECT) from an FTP server.

Each example builds on what has been explained in the previous ones, so we suggest you read them in order.

News Headlines

Many of us feel too busy to read a newspaper every day, but we still want to know what's going on in the world. With AlphaCONNECT, the latest headlines can greet you every morning. The first sample link we'll discuss is called CNN.WRD; it retrieves the news headlines from CNN's World Wide Web site to a Microsoft Word document (a similar sample exists for WordPerfect).

If you want to look at the actual screens as you read this section, start AlphaCONNECT for Microsoft Word, find the link with the description "NEWS: CNN Headlines," and select the *Edit* button.

Here's how we created this link:

1. First, we used our Web browser to find the Web page we wanted to download. The full specification for the page we wanted is *http://www.cnn.com*.
2. Then we started AlphaCONNECT for Microsoft Word.
3. We selected the *New* button to start the Link Editor and create a new link.
4. First, we typed the link description in that field:

   `NEWS: CNN Headlines`

5. Then, on the Source tab of the Link Editor, we selected the Network button, since we will be retrieving this information from the Internet.

6. In the Computer Name field, we typed the complete World Wide Web address for the page:

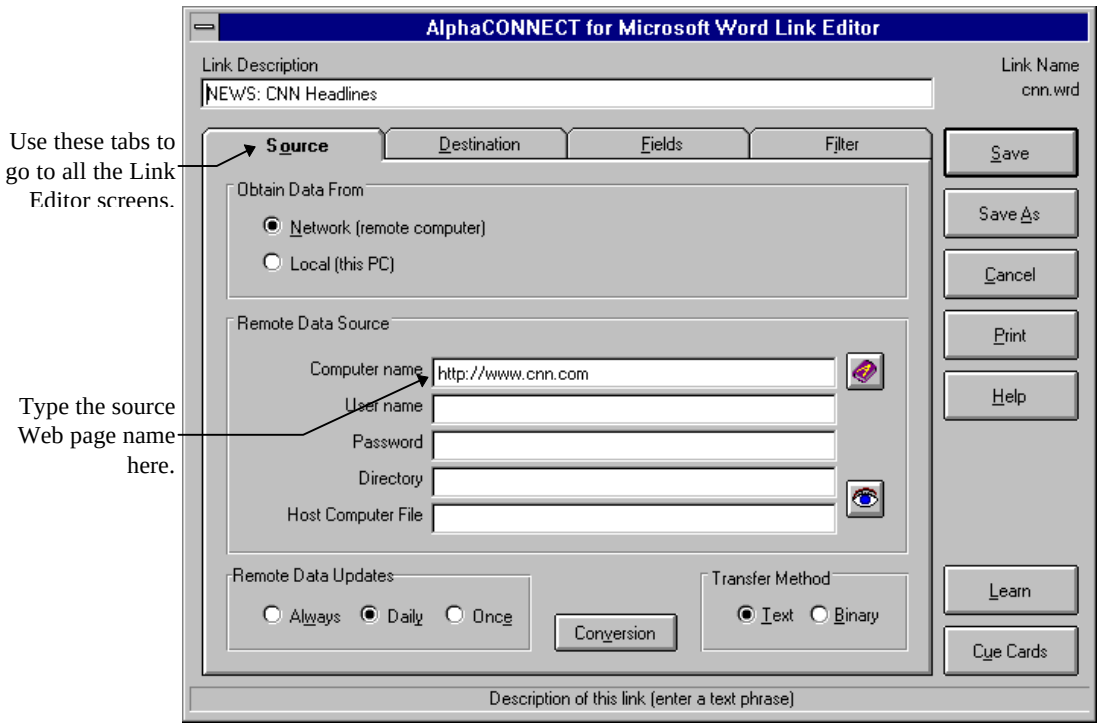
   `www.cnn.com`

   Since this starts with “www,” AlphaCONNECT assumes it is a World Wide Web address, and will add “http://” to the beginning when we save the link. For Web addresses which don’t start with “www,” you must include the “http://.”

   Since you don’t need a user name on the Web, and the Web address specifies the exact file to retrieve, we left the rest of the fields in the Remote Data Source panel blank.

7. CNN updates this page every day, so we checked the *Daily* button for how often to update the data. If we run the link twice on the same day, the second time will use a stored copy of the data from the first run.

8. The file is all text, so we left the *Text* transfer method button checked. We did not select the *Conversion* button, which lets you choose what format to use for the copied Web page file. AlphaCONNECT’s default setting changes the HTML to text, which is right for most Web links. That’s it for this tab; here’s what it looks like:



9. Next, we selected the Destination tab, so we could tell AlphaCONNECT where to put the data on the PC.

10. We wanted the data in a Word document, not a simple Web page, so we left the Microsoft Word Document button selected. We left the default directory, and typed the file name we wanted for the document in the Word Document File field:

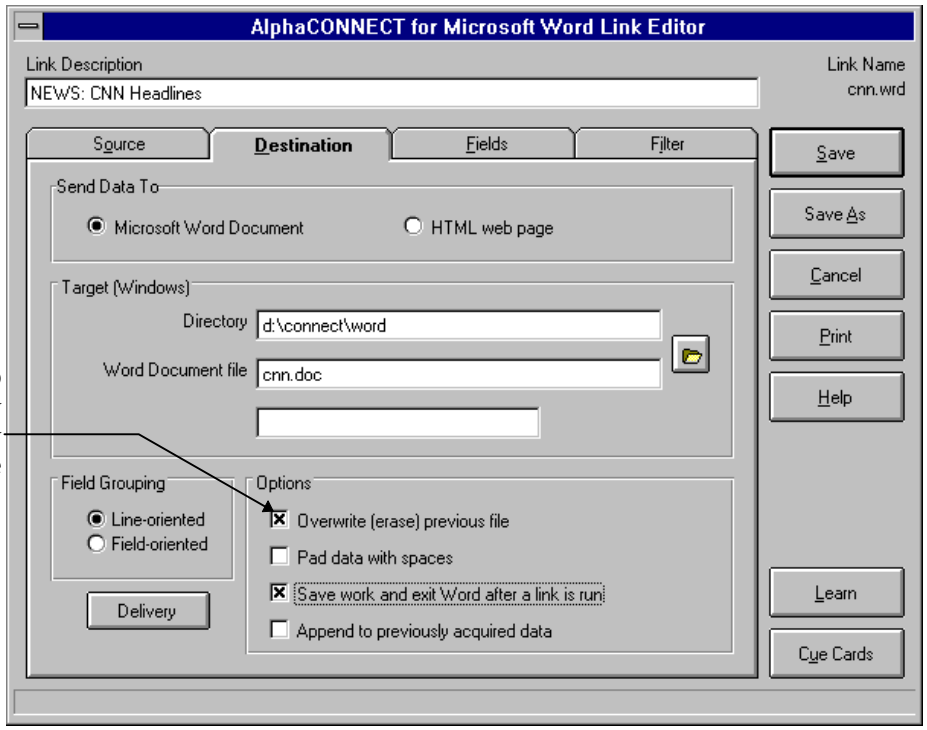
cnn.doc

11. Since we are copying paragraph text into a document, we left Line-oriented selected. The other choice, Field-oriented, is used for columnar data.

12. We checked the box to overwrite the existing file, and didn't check the "Append... Data" box. This way, the file will have only the latest news in it.

13. We did check the "Save work and exit..." box, so AlphaCONNECT will save the document and shut down Word after it runs the link.

14. We don't want to send a copy of the result anywhere else, so we didn't use the *Delivery* button. The Destination tab looks like this:



We wanted to create a new document every time, with only the latest news.

15. Finally, we went to the Fields tab and checked the Pure data type button. The Pure setting tells AlphaCONNECT this is a text file, and we want to retrieve all of the text in it.

16. This link definition is now complete (you'll learn about the other data types and the Filter tab in the next example). We selected *Save As*, and typed the name for the link file: **cnn**. You don't enter a file extension or a directory for an AlphaCONNECT link. All links have extensions based on the component and are stored in the main Alpha-CONNECT directory.

You can run this link by selecting it from the list on the Main Menu and selecting *Run*. If you want to get this information every morning, you can use the Task Bar Scheduler to have the link run automatically every day.

Economic Statistics

Suppose you wanted to see how your company's sales are affected by general trends in the U. S. economy. You have all of the sales figures you need, but it could be cumbersome to get the official employment figures you need in a format you can use. Not with AlphaCONNECT! In fact, one of the included sample links retrieves just that information.

This link is somewhat more complicated than the first one. Its name is ECONOMY; its description is "Statistics: The Economy at a Glance." While we include versions of it for all AlphaCONNECT components, we'll talk about creating the link for Microsoft Excel. We'll break the process down into four parts:

- Getting Started
- Defining the Data Source
- Defining the Destination
- Mapping the Fields

GETTING STARTED

1. Before creating the link, we used AlphaFTP to find the host computer and file we needed. Given the incredible amount of information available on the Internet, this can be the most time-consuming part of link creation.
2. We called up AlphaCONNECT for Microsoft Excel using the AlphaCONNECT Task Bar, then selected the *New* button to create a new link definition.
3. On the Link Editor screen, we typed the definition for the link:

   STATISTICS: The Economy at a Glance

DEFINING THE DATA SOURCE

1. The first tab screen, Source, describes the source file for the link. This link gets data from the Internet, so we made sure *Network* was selected, not *Local PC*.
2. Next, we typed the information for the host computer. Since this host is an FTP site, not a Web page, we had to fill in all the fields:

   Computer name: **stats.bls.gov**
   User name: **anonymous**
   Password: **aconnect@alphamicro.com**
   Directory: **/pub**
   Host Computer File: **Economy.txt**

Notice that, like many FTP sites, this one asks for our email address as the password for the anonymous user name.

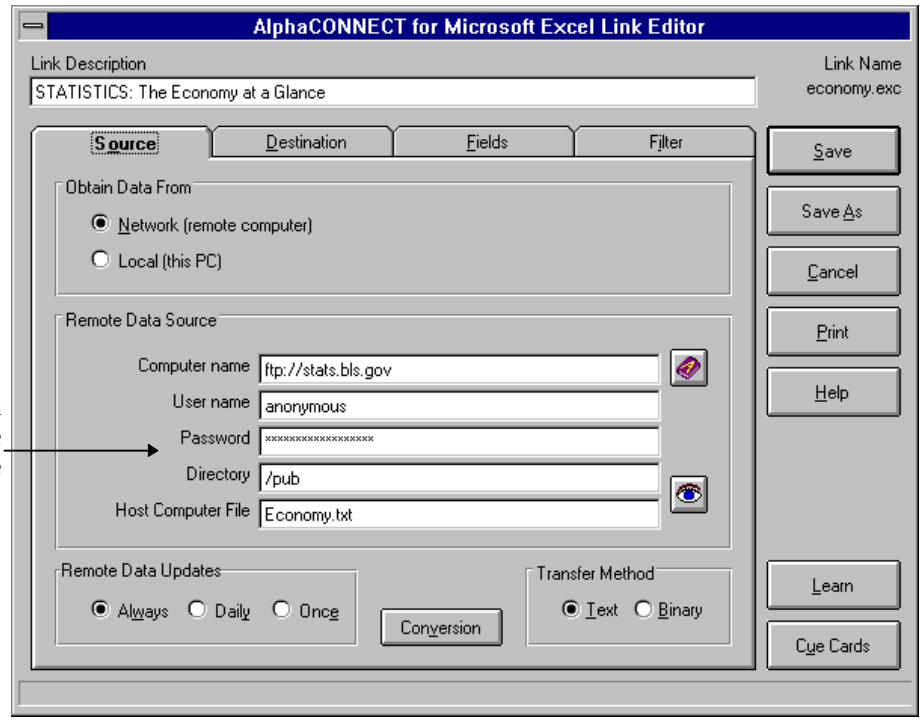
> **Using the Address Book**
> If we had used this computer before, and saved the information in the AlphaCONNECT Address Book, we could have used the Address Book browse button to look up all the host information and copy it into our link with just a few mouse clicks.

3. We didn't know exactly when this information was updated, so we made sure *Always* was selected. This means AlphaCONNECT will always retrieve the data from the host. For links you run often, you can choose to have AlphaCONNECT retrieve the file only once per day, or only the first time the link is run. If it doesn't get the data from the host, AlphaCONNECT uses a stored copy it makes when it runs the link.

4. The file with the economic data is a text file, so we selected the Text file type, not Binary. We didn't need to perform any conversion of the data, so we didn't use that feature.

The Link Editor now looks like this:

For an FTP data source, you have to fill in all these fields.



Notice that AlphaCONNECT displays asterisks instead of the password we entered.

DEFINING THE DESTINATION

1. Next, we selected the Destination tab.

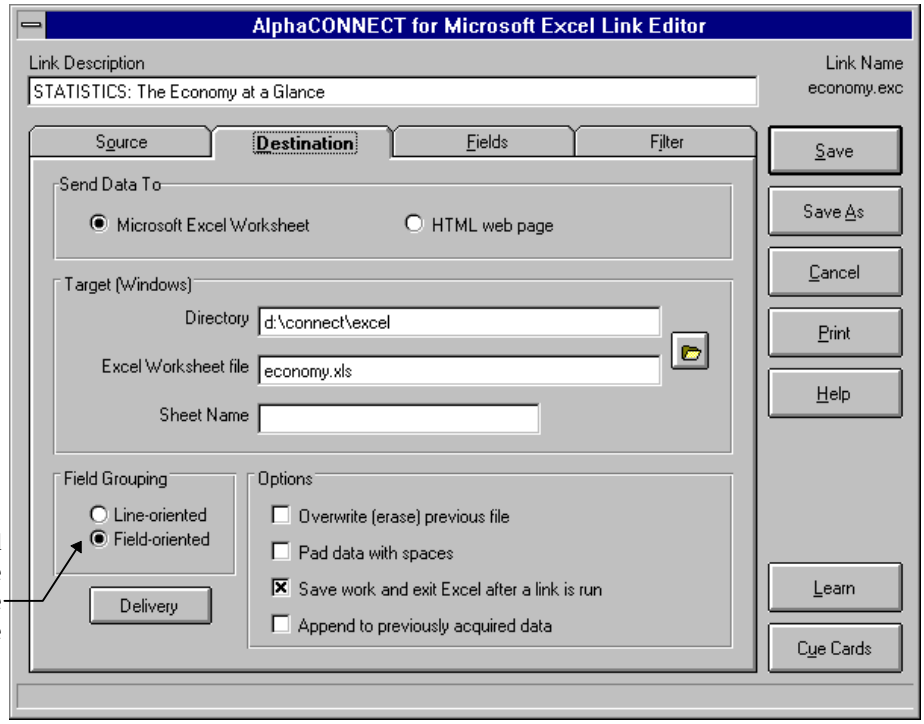
2. We wanted to put the data into a spreadsheet, not a World Wide Web page, so we left the Microsoft Excel Worksheet button selected. Again, we kept the default directory

(we could have used the browse button to select a different one), and typed the name we wanted to give the worksheet. We left sheet name blank, because we want this information to go on Sheet 1 of the file.

3. The source file contains columns of data, which we'll put in separate cells in the spreadsheet, so we selected Field-oriented for the grouping. A line-oriented grouping would put each line of the source in a single cell.

4. We made these decisions for the option boxes:
   - Since this link will place the data in the same location each time, we don't need to erase the previous file for each run—it will be updated with the latest information. So we left that box blank.
   - We don't need to pad the data with spaces to fill out a column; so that box stays unchecked.
   - We'll be running this link automatically, so we checked the box to have Alpha-CONNECT save the file and exit Excel.
   - We don't want to append each run's data to the previous one, so we didn't check that box.

We wanted the data for ourselves, not to send to anyone else, so we didn't use the *Delivery* option. The Destination tab ends up looking like this:



Field-oriented imports separate fields on the same line as separate items.

MAPPING THE FIELDS

1. Next, we went to the Fields tab. For this type of data, this is the most complicated part of a link definition.

2. The first thing to do on this screen is select the Data Source Type. The file we're importing is a "typical" data file: it has repeating lines of data organized into columns. So, we selected the *Typical* button.

   The typical data type is the most flexible in AlphaCONNECT. Because the data is in columns, you can specify exactly where you want it put in the destination file. Of course, most flexible can also mean most complicated. But as you'll see, even the most complicated type of definition isn't too bad.

3. The Field Mapping grid tells AlphaCONNECT exactly which parts of the data source you want to import, and where to put them in the destination file (in this case, our Excel spreadsheet). You can type this information into the grid or, as we did, select the *Learn* feature to define it using the mouse.

4. The Learn feature imports the first page of the destination file from the host computer and displays it on your screen. At first, the entire file is marked to import. You then take the mouse and mark the areas you don't want—separating columns, skipping irrelevant information, etc.

   We wanted all the information in the file, so we used the Learn screen just to split the data by marking out a single space between each two columns. Then, we selected *Update* to return to the Fields tab.

   Using the Mouse
   You can mark fields on the Report Learner only by dragging the mouse from left to right; dragging from right to left has no effect. If you mark an area by mistake, just mark it again to reverse your action.

5. The Learn screen and the Field Mapping grid are interconnected; the selections we made on the Learn screen were reflected in the grid, and any changes made in the grid also change the column marking on the Learn screen. You can go back and forth between the Learn screen and the Field tab as often as you want until the mapping is exactly how you want it.

6. The Field Mapping grid looked like this:

Pag	Lin	Col	Siz	Field
*	*	1	33	A*
*	*	35	10	B*
*	*	46	10	C*
*	*	57	10	D*
*	*	68	10	E*
*	*	79	10	F*
*	*	90	10	G*
*	*	101	10	H*
*	*	112	10	I*
*	*	123	10	J*

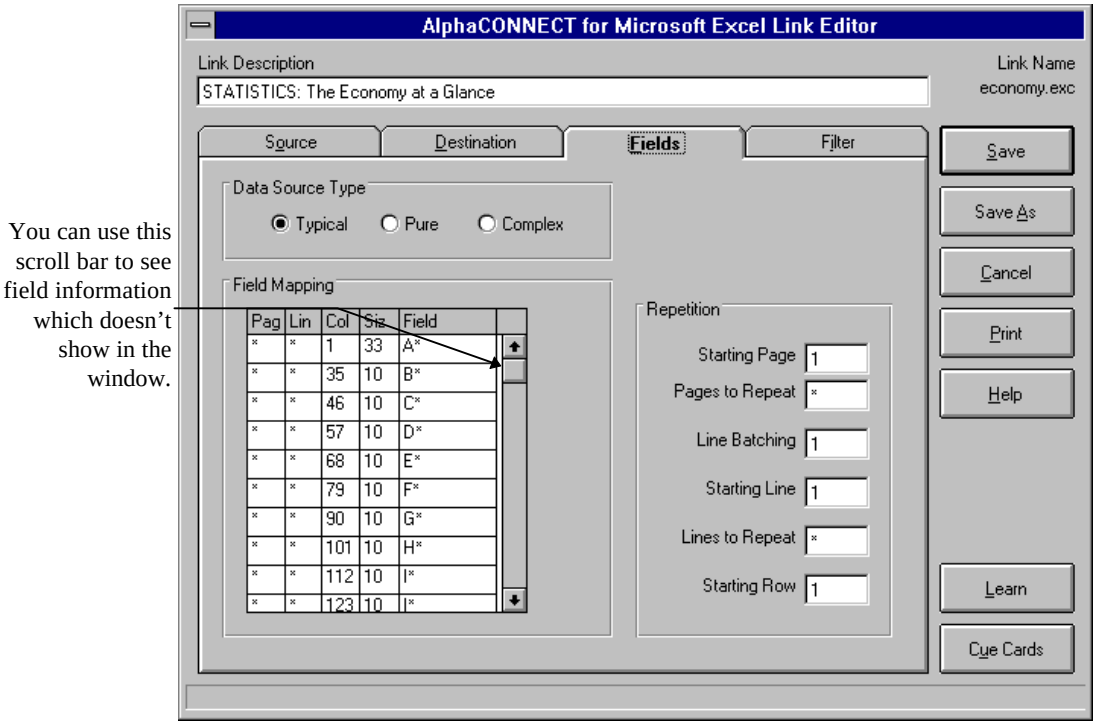
   The asterisks in the first two columns mean that these are repeating fields; we want to import the information from repeating lines and put it in successive rows of the

spreadsheet. The column and size numbers are where each field starts and how many characters are in it.

The final column determines where the information goes in the spreadsheet. The Learn feature automatically places each field in the next available column. Again, the asterisks indicate repeating data. If you didn't like the order of the data in the source file, you could re-order it by changing the column letters in the Field column.

So, this grid shows us that the first field we want to import starts in column 1, is 33 characters long, and goes into column A of the spreadsheet. The second field starts in column 35, has ten characters, and goes into column B, and so on.

7. All that was left was to tell AlphaCONNECT which rows to import. The repetition fields let us do that. These fields let you say what page and row to start on, and how many lines to take from each page. We wanted all the data in the report (which is just a few lines, anyway), so we left the default entries, which import all the lines from the file. Finally, the Fields tab looked like this:



8. But, there were some blank lines and footnotes in the source file that we didn't want in our spreadsheet. We selected the Filter tab to tell AlphaCONNECT to omit them.

9. First, we left the "Ignore Blank Lines..." box checked so we wouldn't have blank rows inserted in the spreadsheet.

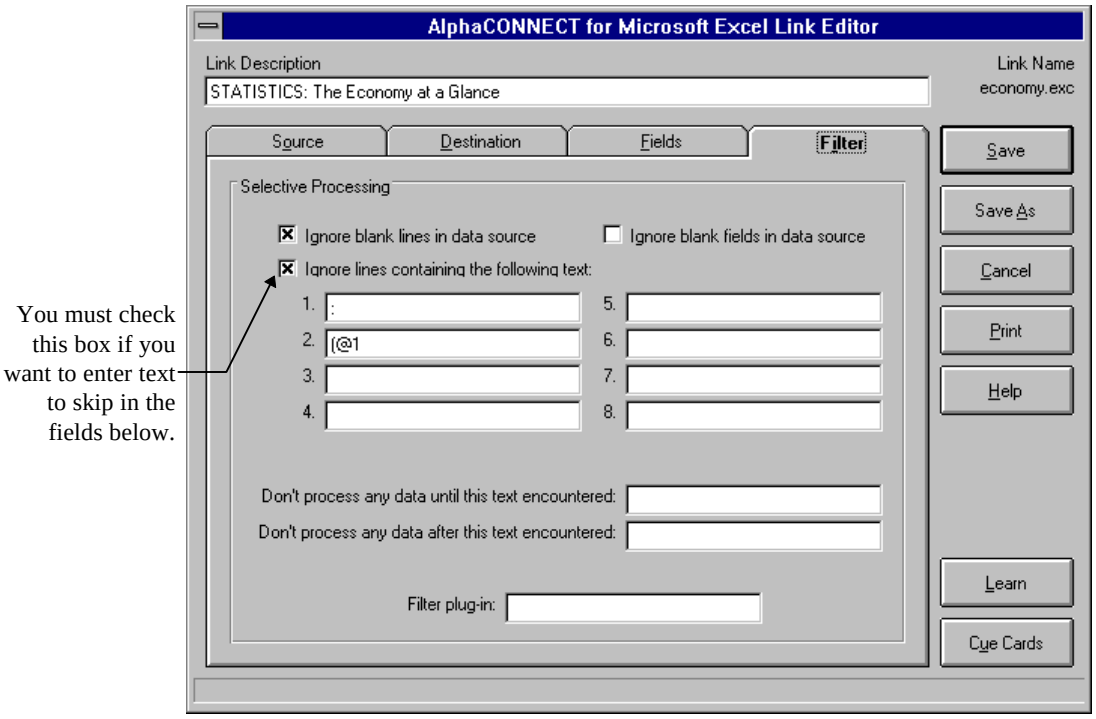
10. Looking at the footnote lines (using the Learn feature showed us the source file), we noticed that the footnote lines all had one of two things that the data lines didn't:

    - a colon (:) somewhere on the line
    - a left parenthesis in the first column

11. So, we checked the “Ignore Lines Containing...” box, and made these two entries in the first two fields:

```
:
(@1
```

The first line tells AlphaCONNECT to ignore any line containing a colon; the second (because of the “@1”), tells it to ignore lines with a left parenthesis in column one. Lines with a parenthesis anywhere else will be processed. Here’s the Filter tab:



We could also have skipped the footnotes by entering **FOOTNOTES** in the “Don’t process any data after...” field.

12. Our link definition was now complete. To save it, we selected *Save As* and entered the name of: **ECONOMY**. Again, you don’t enter a file extension or a directory for a link.

You can run the link to see its results by selecting it from the link list in the Excel component (there are similar links in the other components), then selecting *Run*. Or, you can see the link definition by selecting it, then selecting *Edit*. From the Link Editor, you can print the definition by selecting *Print*.

State Population Web Page

Our final example shows some of the options you have when creating a Web page to post on the Internet or a corporate intranet. It takes state population data from a text file included with AlphaCONNECT and creates an HTML file readable by Web browser programs such as Netscape.

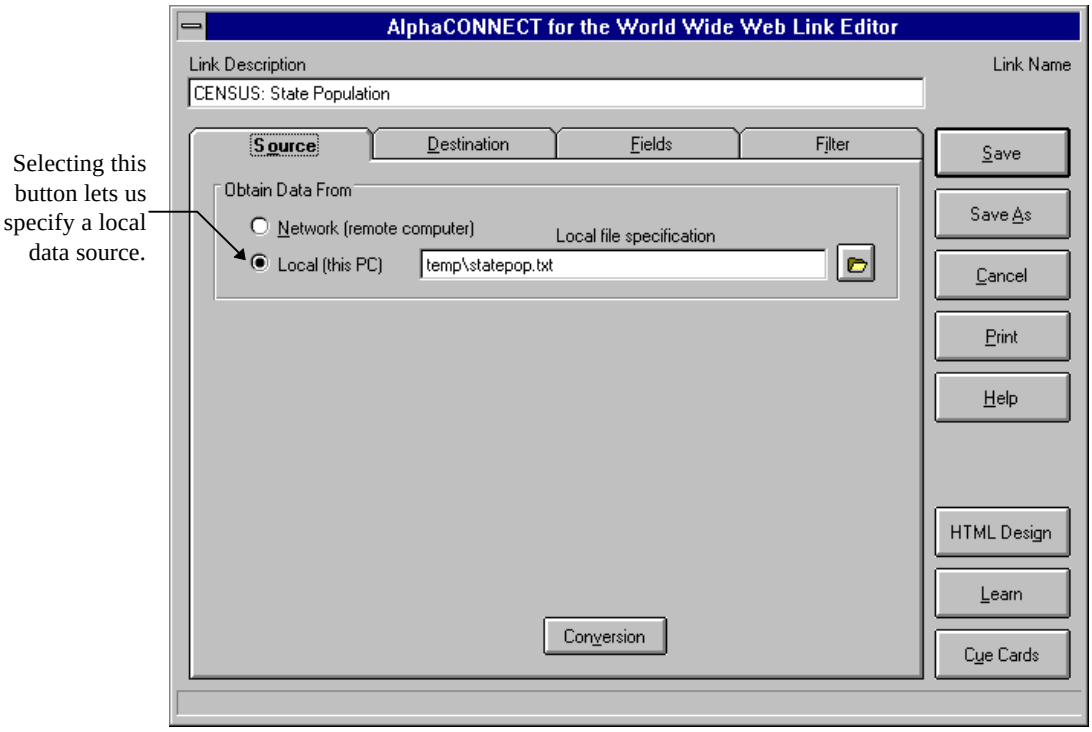
As you'll see in the steps below, creating a Web page follows the same procedure as retrieving information into any of AlphaCONNECT's other target applications, with one additional step: designing the destination Web page. AlphaCONNECT offers three ways for you to do this, ranging from using AlphaCONNECT's default settings to importing the data into an existing Web design you've created outside AlphaCONNECT. This example illustrates the middle way—using AlphaCONNECT's HTML design wizard, which lets you control the major aspects of the page's appearance.

The link is called STATEPOP.WWW. Here's how we created it:

1. We started AlphaCONNECT for the World Wide Web and selected the *New* button.
2. On the Link Editor, we typed the description: **`CENSUS: State Population`**
3. The information we wanted was already on our local computer, so we selected the Local option under Obtain Data From.
4. We knew the file containing the data, so we typed its path in the Local File Specification field: **`temp\statepop.txt`**. Since this doesn't start with a drive letter or a backslash, it's a relative path: the \TEMP directory under the current directory. This allows the link to work no matter what drive and directory you install AlphaCONNECT in.

   If we hadn't been sure of the file location, we could have used the browse button to the right of the field to search our local disk for it.

   That's all we needed to do on the Source tab; no conversion is necessary. The tab looks like this:

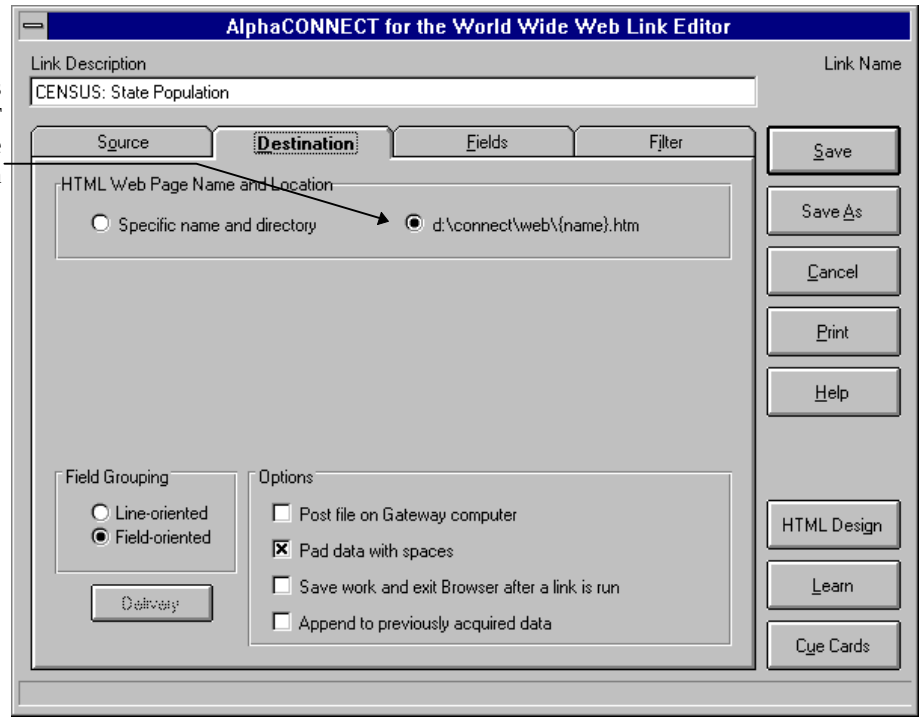


5. Next, we went to the Destination tab.

   We didn't need to do too much here, either. We'll create the default destination file, in the \WEB subdirectory, with the same name as the link. Since we haven't saved the link (and assigned it a name) yet, AlphaCONNECT can't show us what the file name will be.

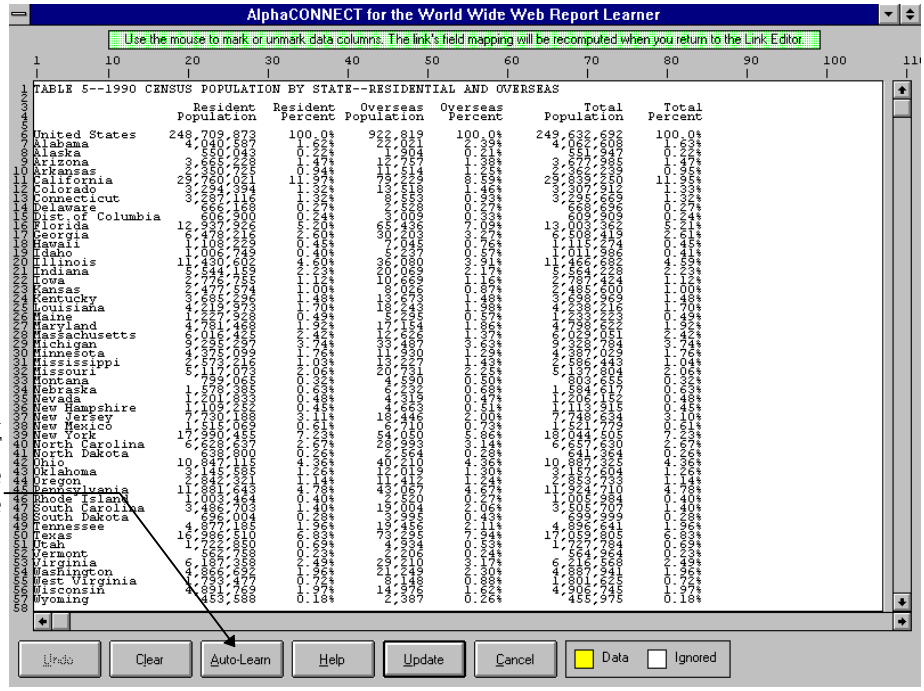
6. The source file is in columns, so we left the Field-oriented grouping selected. Of the other options, we chose only Pad Data with Spaces. Here's the final Destination tab:

This button tells AlphaCONNECT to create the default destination file.



7. Next, we went to the Fields tab and, since this file contains columns of information, selected Typical as the Data Source Type. Then, we selected *Learn* so we could use the mouse to define the columns to import. This is what the Report Learner looked like:

This button tell AlphaCONNECT to analyze the report and define each column.

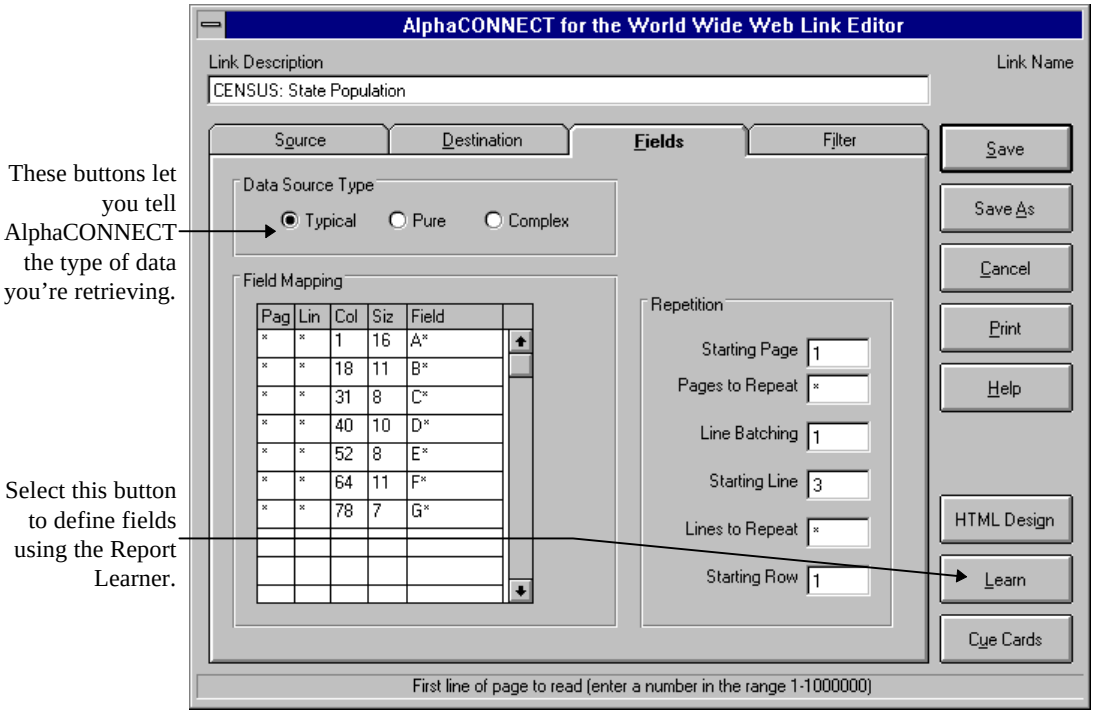


8. Actually, we had AlphaCONNECT define the fields for us—we selected the *Auto-Learn* button. This tells AlphaCONNECT to analyze the report, and define each column as a separate field. A dialog box asks which rows and columns you want

AlphaCONNECT to use to do this. We selected rows 3 - 20 (we skipped the first two rows because they aren't part of the table) and columns 1 - 90, the entire width of the chart.

Sometimes after using *Auto-Learn*, you need to slightly adjust the definitions from the ones AlphaCONNECT selected. In this case, we didn't; it defined each column the way we wanted it. So, we selected *Update* to return to the Fields tab.

9. All that remained on the field tab was to tell the link not to import the first two lines of the file—we didn't want the report heading on the Web page. So, in the Repetition section, we set Starting Line to 3. Here's the Fields tab:



10. We don't need to use the Filter tab at all with this link; starting at row 3 we want to process every line of the file. So, all that's left is to design how our Web page will look. We selected *HTML Design* so we could do just that.

11. The first choice is which of the three methods of page design you want to use. We picked the middle option, Wizard. This gave us more control than Simple, which just uses a default format, and it doesn't require us to know HTML, which we would need if we wanted to design a template to use with the Template option.

    When we selected Wizard, several fields displayed on the screen; these fields let us design the Web page.

12. We don't want to use any special graphics files for either the background or the title area of the page, so we didn't check those boxes. If we had, we could have then entered the name of a graphics file to display.

We also left the font boxes unchecked; they let you change the font size and choose whether it's bold, italic, or underlined.

13. Under the Formatting section, we did make some changes. We wanted to format the data as a table, not as columns, so we checked that option. We also selected Horizontal Rules and Uniform Width Fields, and deselected Monospaced, since the table will format correctly and look better using a proportional font.

14. We want our page to look as good as possible from any browser, so we checked both the HTML 3.0 and Netscape boxes in the Compatibility section.

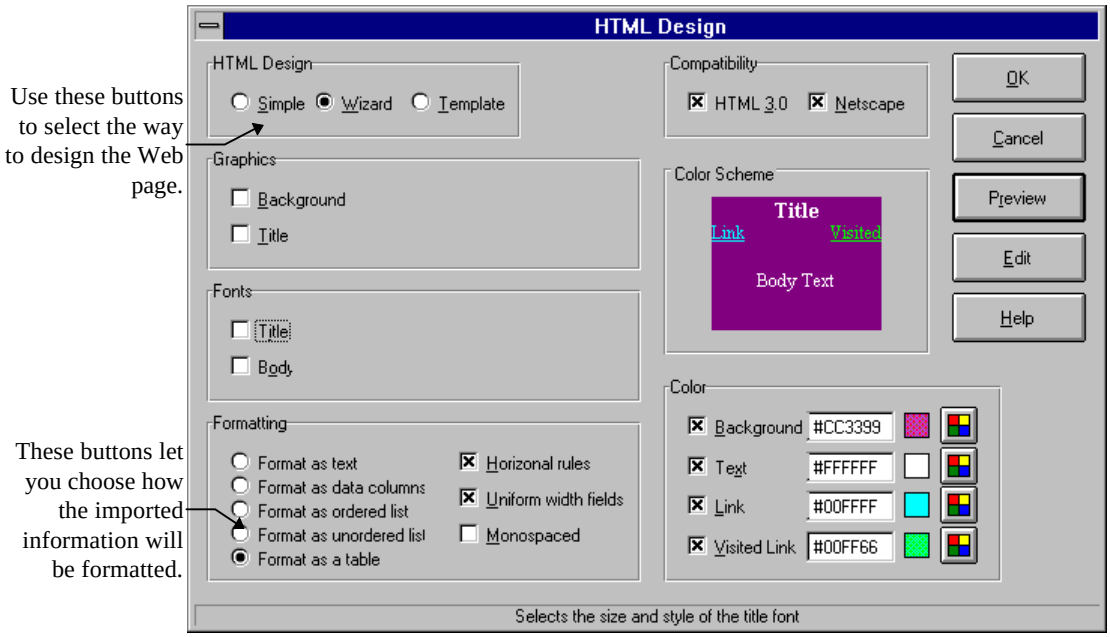
15. All that's left is to choose the colors to use. You can set four colors: background, text, link references, and link references that the user has already visited. To set the background color, we checked that box, then selected the color button that appeared to the right of the field.

    We picked a magenta for our background color, three up and three in from the lower left corner of the palette. (We chose all the colors for our sample for contrast, not for the best appearance.) Then, we selected *OK* to return to the HTML Design screen. The text in the Background field is a hexadecimal representation of the color we chose. If you are familiar with this way of specifying a color, you can type the number you want instead of choosing one from the palette, but, for most people, the palette is much easier.

Color Palettes

Since we had Netscape compatibility checked, the color dialog showed the Netscape color palette, which is different than the Windows colors. It has only 215 colors, and many of them are not the same as any of the colors in the Windows 256 color palette, so AlphaCONNECT displays as close a match as it can.

16. Then, we repeated the process for the other colors, choosing white text, light blue for links, and light green for visited links. The HTML Design screen finally looked like this:



17. We were ready to save the link, so we selected *OK* to go back to the Link Editor, then selected *Save As* to save the link. For the link name, we entered **STATEPOP**. Remember, AlphaCONNECT assigns the extension (for Web links, .WWW) to the link and places all link definitions in the directory where you installed AlphaCONNECT.

PART 4 - OVERVIEW

The samples in the previous section covered only some of the choices you have when creating a link, and didn't even mention AlphaCONNECT's other features. This part of the manual is a quick overview of all of AlphaCONNECT's abilities. It is divided into three parts:

- Link Options and Abilities talks about your choices when you're creating your links.
- Menu Options briefly describes the commands on each AlphaCONNECT component's menus.
- The Task Bar covers the features of the AlphaCONNECT Task Bar.

Link Options and Abilities

The basic function of any AlphaCONNECT link is to get the data you want from a source file and put it in the type of file you want on your PC. But, that's not all a link can do; a number of options let you control how the information is brought to you, and even let you pass it on to other people if you want. The sections below briefly describe some of the things you can do in a link. For more details, see the cue card text for the individual fields and AlphaCONNECT's on-line help.

SOURCE FILE OPTIONS

In addition to choosing the fields to import from the source file, you can use the Filter tab to tell AlphaCONNECT to skip certain lines or fields, to not start until it encounters text you choose, or to stop when it reaches particular text.

If you're importing from a Web page, you can either convert the HTML source file to text, or keep the HTML commands intact; in most cases, you'll want to convert it to text. You can use the *Conversion* button on the Source tab to change this option.

IMPORT AND FORMATTING OPTIONS

Once AlphaCONNECT has extracted the data you want, you have your choice of how to import it into the destination file. Options on the Destination tab let you create a new file every time or add the data to an existing file, and choose where to insert it in the file. Exactly how these options work depends on the target application. For example, by default, Microsoft Word adds text to the end of an existing document, while Excel starts at the beginning of the worksheet, which could overwrite previous data. So, be sure to set these options correctly.

When you're using AlphaCONNECT for the World Wide Web, the *HTML Design* feature lets you choose among ways of formatting the Web page you create. You can let Alpha-

CONNECT create a simple page for you, use the Web wizard to choose colors, fonts, and graphics to use, or tell AlphaCONNECT to use a page template you've already created.

DELIVERY OPTIONS

You may want to forward the data you've collected to other people in your organization, or outside it. With AlphaCONNECT, you can. Delivery options let you post a Web page to your gateway computer (from the World Wide Web component only), and/or send a file to any system you can reach via FTP. If you have the AlphaCONNECT Messenger email add-on, you can send the output file as an attachment to an email message—to anyone or everyone you can mail to, anywhere in the world.

The Destination tab contains the delivery options—choose the *Delivery* button if you want to use the FTP or email feature.

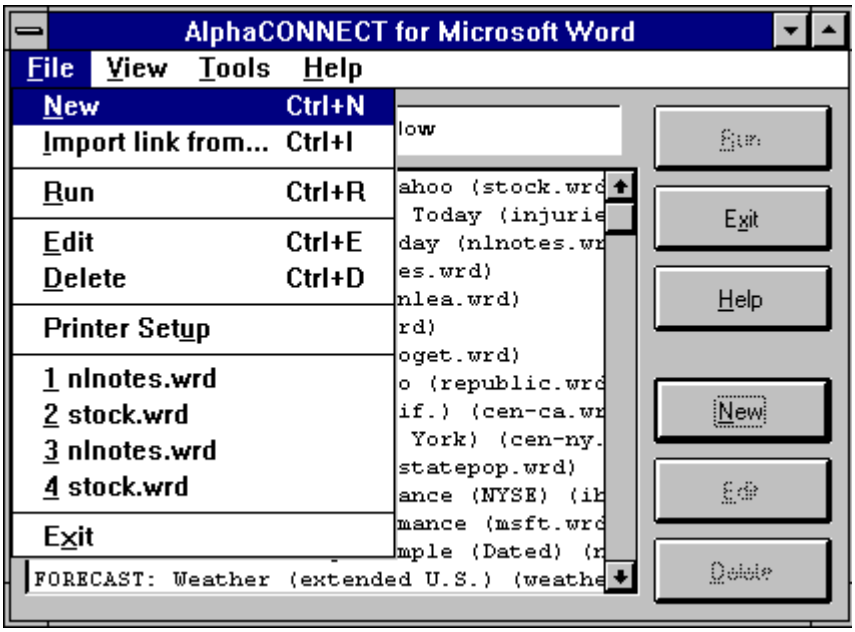
PLUG-IN PROGRAMS

In addition to AlphaCONNECT's standard options, it supports plug-in programs. Plug-ins are programs written by you or someone else which can interact with AlphaCONNECT. You can have a link use a plug-in program to manipulate the source data before it's imported, convert the data to another format, or deliver it to any destination. See the Programming Information topic in the on-line help or the developer's section of our Web page for more about plug-ins.

Menu Options

This section contains brief descriptions of everything you can do in an AlphaCONNECT component (the Task Bar has additional features). It is intended to introduce you to all of AlphaCONNECT's abilities and features. It does not give detailed instructions on using the features; if you need instructions, see AlphaCONNECT's help file. The more involved features—defining links and setting options—also have cue card help available, which displays a description of each current field as you use the feature.

The features in this section are grouped by AlphaCONNECT menu. This picture of AlphaCONNECT for Microsoft Word shows the File Menu:



File Menu Options

New: Creates a new, blank, link. Displays the Link Editor screen so you can define the link. Same as selecting the *New* button.

Import Link From: Copies a link from another AlphaCONNECT component to this one. You may need to modify the link definition so it formats the data the way you want it for this application.

Run: Runs the currently highlighted link. If you haven't selected a link yet, it does nothing. Same as selecting the *Run* button.

Edit: Lets you change the definition of the currently selected link. Same as selecting the *Edit* button.

Delete: Erases the currently selected link. AlphaCONNECT asks if you are sure before deleting the link. Same as selecting the *Delete* button.

Printer Setup: Displays the standard Windows Print Setup dialog box so you can change your printer settings.

1 - 4: These are the last four links you've run from this component. Selecting a link from this list runs the link.

Exit: Leaves AlphaCONNECT. Same as selecting the *Exit* button.

View Menu Options

Description Order: Lists the links in the link window in alphabetical order by description, with the description at the beginning of the line. This is the default.

Filename Order: Lists the links in the link window in alphabetical order by link file name, with the file name at the beginning of the line.

History: You must have a link selected to use this option. It shows information about the last time the link was run—the date and time and whether it was successful, and when the link was created and last revised. You can also print this information.

Source: You must have a link selected to use this option. It uses the Notepad to show you the data source retrieved by the last run of the link.

Target File: You must have a link selected to use this option. For links that create application files, this starts the application and opens the target file of the link. The exact wording of this option changes to reflect the component you're using. For example, in AlphaCONNECT for Microsoft Word, it says Target Document. This option is never available in the World Wide Web component.

HTML Page: You must have a link selected to use this option. For links that create World Wide Web pages, this starts your Web browser program and displays the created page.

Options: This displays your current option settings and lets you change them. The options include information about the default host computer, data import method, target application behavior, Web browser, FTP program, and more.

Tools Menu Options

FTP: Starts the FTP program you use with AlphaCONNECT, either the internal AlphaFTP or another FTP program you've chosen. You can use this to find information about your data source before defining a link. If you use AlphaFTP, you'll find information on all of its features in AlphaCONNECT's on-line help.

World Wide Web: Starts the Web browser you've defined for use with AlphaCONNECT. You can use this to look at Web pages you've created with AlphaCONNECT, or to find World Wide Web sites you may want to use as data sources.

Address Book: The Address Book can hold address and sign-on information about the host computers you use. It is shared among all AlphaCONNECT components. When defining links, you can select a host from the Address Book rather than having to type the information again. This option lets you add, change, or print Address Book entries.

Help Menu Options

Contents: Starts AlphaCONNECT's on-line help, with the table of contents displayed.

Search: Starts AlphaCONNECT's on-line help and displays the topic index.

Frequently Asked Questions: Displays a list of questions frequently asked about AlphaCONNECT.

Registration Information: Lets you display or print the registration information: name, company, and registration code.

About: Displays information about your AlphaCONNECT installation: software version, current memory usage, and so on.

The AlphaCONNECT Task Bar

The AlphaCONNECT Task Bar makes it easy for you to start any AlphaCONNECT component. It is also the only way to access the AlphaCONNECT Scheduler, which lets you schedule links to run automatically. If you have all of AlphaCONNECT's components installed, the Task Bar looks like this:

Most PCs will not have all of the components installed, so your Task Bar will probably have fewer buttons than the one shown here.

To use a Task Bar feature, you just click on the button you want. Here's what each button does:

Starts AlphaCONNECT for the World Wide Web.

Starts AlphaCONNECT for Microsoft Excel.

Starts AlphaCONNECT for Microsoft Word.

Starts AlphaCONNECT for Microsoft Access.

Starts AlphaCONNECT for WordPerfect.

Starts AlphaCONNECT for Quattro Pro.

Starts AlphaCONNECT for Borland Paradox.

Starts AlphaFTP.

Takes you to the AlphaCONNECT Address Book.

	Starts the AlphaCONNECT Scheduler. See the on-line help for more information and instructions on using the Scheduler.
	Moves the Task Bar. Each arrow takes the bar to a different edge of your screen.
	Starts AlphaCONNECT help.
	Closes the Task Bar. Remember, the Task Bar must be running when it is time to start a scheduled link.

We’re Here to Help

As a last word, remember, we’re easily available if you need us. If you have a question about AlphaCONNECT, or a problem, and you can’t find the answer in the on-line help or in this manual, here’s what you can do:

- Look at the list of frequently asked questions (FAQs) on our World Wide Web page: *http://www.alphamicro.com/ac* We update the FAQs frequently based on the information we get from our users.
- If you haven’t yet purchased and registered your copy of AlphaCONNECT, call 888/226-6398 or send email to us at this address: *aconnect@alphamicro.com.*
- If you have registered AlphaCONNECT, call us at 800/487-7877. Telephone support is free for the first 30 days after you register; after that, there will be a per-call charge, so please have your credit card available when you call.
- If you just have a question, and an immediate response isn’t critical, you can send email to *support@alphamicro.com* or send us a fax at 714/641-7605. We’ll respond to email and fax issues as time is available, so you may have to wait a few days for an answer.